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Unpacking the Harmonization of National Anti-Doping Policy: A Collaborative Autoethnography Through the Lens of Institutional Entrepreneurship

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ABSTRACT

National sport policies' harmonization with the World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA) has been one of the most researched topics within the sport policy domain. The literature, however, has failed to offer firsthand empirical insights from those actors who develop the policy so that harmonization occurs. The present study fills this gap by drawing on the tenets of institutional entrepreneurship to unpack the process through the experiences of the person responsible for it. The study employs a collaborative analytical autoethnography where, through memo-writings, emails, and reflective notes by the second author, it micro-theorizes the political, technical, and cultural activities that the institutional entrepreneur carried in order to harmonize Montenegro's anti-doping policy with WADA. The study reveals that the harmonization process entails seven institutional works: boundary spanning, scanning the environment, repairing bilateral relationships, designing the new legislation, modifying structures, framing the need, and transferring responsibility. This is the first empirical study in sport management literature to examine institutional change for sport policy-making through the lenses of institutional entrepreneurship and a collaborative autoethnographic perspective.

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Institutional work; WADA; Montenegro; NADO

1. Introduction

One stream of sport policy research that has attracted the community's interest has been anti-doping. This is perhaps not surprising given the 'competition corruption' (Roberts et al., 2018) through continuous doping scandals in various sports (athletics, cycling, weightlifting, skiing, etc.). Research on this issue intensified particularly

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after the establishment of the World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA) in 1999 (Pielke & Boye, 2019). Essentially, 1999 marks the beginning of institutionalized anti-doping. Afterall, WADA is legitimized by an international convention under the United Nations, ratified by almost 200 countries, making it arguably one of the most successful examples of international cooperation in history (ibid.).

Soon after WADA was established, studies started highlighting the challenges related to harmonizing anti-doping policies across different countries, concluding that a policy network approach is the best way to understand the implementation process (Houlihan, 1999). Since then, scholars have started to empirically examine the implementation of anti-doping policies in both international and national settings. For example, Kustec-Lipicer and McArdle (2012) showed how the adoption of anti-doping policies impacted Slovenia's domestic policy changes, with controversy and disaffection being caused during the process. Moreover, those monitoring compliance with WADA's Code reported additional implementation challenges, especially when parallel compliance with other international agreements (for example, money laundering) has been the case (Gray, 2019). Indeed, Henning and Andreasson (2022) noted that WADA's hegemony is often even challenged, given the interdependence between national and international anti-doping laws. At the same time, other studies put forward that bilateral collaboration can strengthen the implementation of anti-doping policies (Hanstad & Houlihan, 2015), especially in powerful sporting countries with distinctive political systems (for example, China, in Yang et al., 2022). Harmonization can differ even between countries with no particularly great cultural differences (Wagner & Hanstad, 2011). Star (2023), drawing on India's case, went even further to point out the impact that a lack of harmonization in the implementation of WADA's Code can have on the legitimacy of the overall anti-doping framework. Interestingly, research has also shown that although more funding does not lead to better anti-doping, implementing anti-doping policies contributes to nations' economies (Martensen & Møller, 2017).

Although these indicative empirical studies have offered distinct, granular insights on the matter of compliance and implementation of anti-doping policies, an understanding of the process leading up to the harmonization of such a national policy is largely missing. The present study follows recent developments within the broader sport policy research (e.g. Lu & Heinze, 2021) and builds on the institutional entrepreneurship literature (Battilana et al., 2009) and institutional work (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006), to offer an insider's empirical perspective on how harmonization actually happens. In doing so, it largely responds to recent calls of 'how does institutional work shape policy and practice to address the world's grand challenges?' (Robertson et al., 2022, p. 468).

2. Literature Review & Theoretical Background

2.1. Towards Safeguarding the Integrity of Sport Through Anti-Doping Policies

The United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO), WADA, and the Council of Europe (CoE) all aim to promote safe and clean sport through the work of various instruments, rules, and regulations. With respect to

internationally binding norms, governments and sports movements alike are asked to comply with the global anti-doping framework based on the International Convention against Doping in Sport (UNESCO Convention) and the World Anti-Doping Code (WADC). Beyond WADA's WADC, the International Standards (IS) represent the policy framework aimed at significantly reducing doping in sport.

Against this background, the extant research focus on anti-doping is on prohibited substances (Mazzoni et al., 2011), human rights with respect to the doping control procedure (Waddington & Møller, 2014), or general approach towards compliance (Houlihan, 2014). Regarding anti-doping policy, scholars have largely investigated developed systems (Ritchie & Jackson, 2014; Star, 2023). Houlihan and Hanstad (2019) clustered existing studies around WADA effectiveness and specific aspects of anti-doping policy. McArdle's (2021) analysis of the situation in Belarus is noteworthy, as it underscores the close ties between independent national antidoping authorities and corrupt, oppressive regimes. As far as compliance is concerned, the focus is on technical aspects, such as systems, testing procedures, and therapeutic use exemptions (Yang et al., 2022). According to Gray (2019), the challenges towards compliance with WADC are no different from compliance with other international binding norms.

Considering these binding instruments, the first step towards compliance on the national level presupposes that governments ratify and incorporate the UNESCO Convention in their legal system. Secondly, the National Olympic Committee (in some cases including the Paralympic Committee) and the National Anti-Doping Organization (NADO), as signatories, all adopt the rules enacted by the WADC. These two interrelated processes depend heavily on the constitutional setting and socio-political environment.

The UNESCO Convention and the WADC have monitoring systems in place, albeit with different methodological approaches to access compliance. In the case of the UNESCO Convention, the focus is on the holistic approach, with a minimum range of 60% to be compliant, while in the case of WADC the aim is to have an independent and professional NADO in place with legal personality adopting national anti-doping regulations to facilitate legal, institutional, and operational harmonization with the WADC. The WADC constitutes a set of mandatory rules and procedures for how the NADOs will be accessed and steps towards achieving or maintaining compliance through a transparent and self-reporting process developed by WADA and controlled by the Compliance Review Committee (CRV). As of 2015, the CRV is established as an independent, non-political working body that provides advice, guidance, and recommendations to the WADA Executive Committee. This means that the development of anti-doping policies is shaped by both external drivers (WADA, UNESCO) and internal political actors, including cultural settings (Begočić, 2020).

Therefore, it becomes apparent that NADO represents a major institutional national actor responsible for implementing WADC and cooperation with sport movement and public authorities. Within this triangle, the challenge lies in establishing a coherent structure for allocating responsibilities in accordance with the delineation of jurisdiction to achieve the necessary autonomy of the NADO while safeguarding public interest reflected in integrity. Central to the NADO's effort is the process of harmonization through consensus (reaching agreement on values), uniformity (identical standards), proximity (operational similarity), compatibility

(mandatory procedures and processes), and tolerability (acceptable differences) (Houlihan, 2014). Although not our focal unit of analysis, all the aforementioned constitutes the institutional field (as per DiMaggio and Powell's (1991) definition), within which we seek to better understand the harmonization with WADA's institutional 'recipes.'

2.2. Institutional Perspective: Change, Agency, Entrepreneurship, and Work

In the most recent scoping review on the matter, Robertson and colleagues (2022, p. 459) emphatically stated that 'concepts from the institutional theory perspective have become *institutionalized* [emphasis added] in the sport management literature.' Indeed, the institutional perspective has been very popular approach in providing the theoretical underpinning for a macro-sociological understanding of how sport organizations operate, are structured, and relate to each other (Washington & Patterson, 2011). The pick of the utilization of the institutional perspective in sport management concerned a focus on change (Robertson et al., 2022).

Influential and pioneering scholars (e.g. Amis, Slack, Kikulis, O'Brien) tried to better understand the adaptation (or lack thereof) and response of sport organizations to pressures from the external environment. This led the community to start explaining these changes by drawing on the concept of isomorphism—and its associated coercive, mimetic, and normative pressures—as put forward from the neo-institutional approach (DiMaggio & Powell, 1991).

However, the complexity of the institutional environment (see, e.g. Pedras et al., 2020) and, as a result, the resulting strong presence of multiple (conflicting and competing) institutional logics in sport (e.g. Skirstad & Chelladurai, 2011) has brought to the fore various shortcomings related to the perspective's fundamental roots on compliance and conformity (Greenwood & Hinings, 1988), thereby highlighting its apparent inability to explain organizational change. Because of these criticisms, the role of agency in institutional change soon started attracting the attention of the sport management community (Nite & Edwards, 2021) and a corresponding interest in the idea of institutional entrepreneurship (Lu & Heinze, 2021) and the associated institutional works (Dowling & Smith, 2016) carried out by (but not solely) these agents-entrepreneurs, among others.

According to Seo and Creed (2002), the institutional entrepreneurship concept within the institutional perspective may be a possible 'solution' to an apparent contradiction. On one hand, more and more organizations in specific fields seem to abide by and converge around a dominant set of norms and practices. At the same time, we are witnessing the continual emergence of new norms and practices within fields. Therefore, institutional entrepreneurship can shed light on all these manipulative-oriented works that actors perform to accomplish something anew within the structures in which they are embedded (Garud et al., 2002).

In the only study in sport management that has explicitly drawn on institutional entrepreneurship to examine how sport policy unfolds, Lu and Heinze (2021) referred to three broad activities that characterize this concept of the institutional perspective. Through political-related activities, institutional entrepreneurs try to rally different but relevant actors in order to support the former's goals for introducing new

practices and/or altering existing structures and processes. The technical-related activities concern the competence that institutional entrepreneurs present on putting detailed and concrete plans together, so that any new practice, structure, or process is well thought through and appropriately implemented. Finally, the cultural-related activities concern the efforts made by institutional entrepreneurs to frame what they try to create and meaningfully communicate it to the field's actors.

Although Lu and Heinze (2021) referred to and identified several tactics within these activities carried out by institutional entrepreneurs to explain policy change, the present study aligns with the concept of institutional work, which is 'the broad category of purposive action aimed at creating, maintaining, and disrupting institutions' (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006, p. 216). After all, Nite and Edwards (2021) noted that the first of these works—institutional creation—is derived from institutional entrepreneurship, thereby encompassing all three of the activities that Lu and Heinze (2021) referred to through nine types of creation work performed by institutional agents (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006).

3. Case Context and Method

3.1. Background and Research Setting

The sport ecosystem in Montenegro is centralized, meaning that the planning, programming, and coordination of public policies are under the state authority responsible for sport (Begović, 2020). In practice, this relates to the process of strategic development planning, adoption of an action plan, and coordination of related activities being under the Directorate for Sport and Youth (UMS). According to the governmental structure, the Ministry of Education, Science, Culture, and Sport (MPNKS) exercises an administrative supervisory role over the UMS, although the latter has institutional, organizational, and financial independence in the field of sport.

The structure of the sport system, the relationship between public and non-governmental actors, and their roles and responsibilities are all set by the Law on Sport as the main legislation in the field of sport. According to this law, the state represents the main actor in sport in the pyramidal structure of sport. In addition, most funds for sport come directly from the state through a yearly tender implemented by the UMS. The Montenegrin Olympic Committee (COK) is recognized as a central non-governmental sport organization and acts as an association of all National Sport Federations (NSF).

The jurisdictions of COK were set broadly, including a provision on anti-doping policy, where COK is recognized as the main anti-doping institutional actor. According to the Law on Sport, COK is the authority responsible for creating the anti-doping institutional framework, including the adoption, coordination, and implementation of anti-doping-related policies. The COK established the Commission for Anti-Doping (Commission) as a consultative body without legal personality or organizational structure as the WADC foresaw. With this limited scope, at the regulatory level, the Commission did not adopt national anti-doping rules, while at the organizational level, the Commission did not establish a professional structure comprised of the Therapeutic Use Exemption, Disciplinary, and Appellation bodies

that function independently from both public and sport entities with the NADO's autonomy.

It is also worth highlighting the second author's extensive experience and exposure within the given context. This individual has been actively engaged in the Montenegrin sports ecosystem as an athlete, coach, and manager across various sports organizations. Their experience includes serving as the Program Manager for the National Olympic Committee of Montenegro, where they contributed to strategic planning and the implementation of projects *via* the IOC's Olympic Solidarity program. Additionally, the second author held a governance role as a member of the General Assembly of the Montenegrin Tennis Federation. Since 2012, they have been advising the Government of Montenegro on international relations and high-performance sports. At the time of this research (2021), the government invited the second author to take on the role of Acting Director of the primary governmental institution tasked with developing and managing the sports ecosystem.

Against this background, institutional work took place to ensure that the country fully aligned and harmonized with international anti-doping rules and regulations.

3.2. Collaborative Autoethnography

Qualitative in nature, autoethnography is a method that shifts the attention from the perceived reality of research participants to the researcher him/herself (as a subject), thereby giving them a voice towards explaining the phenomenon under study in a self-reflective and often critical, fashion (Ellis & Bochner, 2000). It becomes apparent that the generated knowledge that is reported from the insider (that is, the autoethnographer) offers what other, more traditional qualitative and certainly the deterministic quantitative methods fail to capture; that is, moments of everyday experience (Misener, 2020) through creative texts that are even more accessible to audiences outside of academic settings to improve our own and others' lives (Trussell, 2015).

Within this prism, analytical autoethnographies are discerned by, and present, five key features: (a) the researcher is a full member in a research setting, (b) s/he uses analytical reflexivity, (c) s/he has a visible narrative presence in the written text, (d) s/he engages in dialogue with informants beyond the self, and (e) s/he is committed to theoretical analysis that improves theoretical understandings of broader social phenomena (Anderson, 2006, p. 375). Therefore, the analytical autoethnography goes beyond a mere self-reflection exercise and concerns what Fiske (1990) referred to as 'theoretically structured introspection' (p. 85).

According to Chang et al. (2013), collaborative autoethnography is the process of doing autoethnography with others at varying levels of participation. For instance, there might be cases where researchers go through the same phenomena and have analogous (not identical) experiences. To illustrate the point, Misener (2020) could have captured parental well-being by collaboratively reflecting, discussing emerging themes and analyzing data with another parent from the same setting. The same applies for Lachance (see, Lachance & Parent, 2020) and Kodama (see Kodama et al., 2013) when autoethnographically reporting their volunteering experiences. Another way of exercising collaborative autoethnography is when one or more

researchers document deeply personal experiences and then solicit other researchers for the purposes of joint analysis and interpretation (Nowakowski & Sumerau, 2019). For the purpose of the present article, we adopt the latter way, wherein the second author, as an institutional entrepreneur, documented experiences from his position as acting director in charge of UMS, appointed by the Government of Montenegro. He then recruited the first author to jointly analyze the political, technical, and cultural activities and the associated types of institutional works the second author performed to harmonize national anti-doping policy in his country.

Sport management scholars have recently started embracing autoethnography as a holistic methodology to a much greater extent than they did previously (e.g. Cooper et al. 2017; Kerwin & Hoeber, 2015; Kodama et al., 2013; Lachance & Parent, 2020; Misener, 2020; Wheaton & O'Loughlin, 2017). It is not our intent, nor is it within the scope of the present article, to either repeat the merits of employing an autoethnography or offering detailed accounts of empirical studies that have used it. What is worth mentioning, however, is that unpacking sport policy from an autoethnographic perspective through the lens of institutional entrepreneurship and related institutional work is a methodological-theoretical dyad that—to the best of our knowledge—has not been employed by sport management scholars.

4. Data Collection and Analysis

Keeping in mind Anderson's (2006) features of analytical autoethnographies, data collection was carried out by the second author, who has been a full member of the research setting [see Feature (a)]. For starters, he has served as the program manager at the National Olympic Committee of Montenegro and as a member of the General Assembly of Montenegrin Tennis Federation. From 2012, he served as an advisor for international relations and high-performance sport at the Government of Montenegro. In mid-2012, he was elected to the Governing Board Bureau of the EPAS Council of Europe (CoE), serving two terms. In addition, he has been a member of the task force for good governance in sport, and in 2017, he became a consultant for the CoE on a good governance research project. In July 2021, he became a consultant on anti-doping for the CoE, while in 2021, he was invited by the Government of Montenegro to take over the position of acting director of the Directorate for Sport and Youth (UMS).

Furthermore, the analytical reflexivity ([b], as per Anderson's guide; see next section) was performed through a rich set of field notes consisting of emails, official memos, meetings, and media appearances. Table 1 provides a more analytical picture of the dataset itself, demonstrating the second author's engagement with informants beyond himself ([d], as per Anderson's guide).

The collaborative autoethnography proved useful for theoretically analyzing this rich dataset. This is because it enabled the combination of what Blumer (1969, p. 38) called 'firsthand familiarity' with the experience and phenomenon under study (see second author) and the first author's observation of the experience, as well as his familiarity with the theoretical approach underpinning this study. Specifically, the analysis was carried out in four stages. Firstly, in order not only to maintain the needed analytical reflexivity but also to have a visible narrative presence in the

Table 1. Dataset Volume.

Organizational entity	Written communication	Number of online/ physical meetings
International/intergovernmental organizations	80 emails	17 meetings
Council of Europe	3 memos	
WADA		
UNESCO		
Public institutions	35 emails	30 meetings
MNE Government	55 memos	
MPNKS		
Ministry of Finance		
Secretariat for Legislation		
Parliament Committees		
University of Montenegro		
Sport Movement	14 emails	43 meetings
National Sport Federations COK/Commission on Anti-Doping	25 memos	
Diplomatic representatives to MNE Embassies	10 emails	10 meetings
Diplomats-Representations	5 memos	
Media in Montenegro	45 articles	15 media (TV & Radio) appearances

written text ([c], as per Anderson's guide), the second author developed a reflective narrative based on the events outlined in the above timeline. Secondly, whenever deemed necessary and/or 'powerful/illustrative, this narrative was substantiated by the relevant data (emails, press articles, memos, etc.). In the third stage, the first author went through the reflective narrative to discerning types of institutional works. He did so in an abductive way, meaning that he was theoretically analyzing the narrative having in mind the political, technical, and cultural activities that broadly institutional entrepreneurs engage with (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006; Perkmann & Spicer, 2007), but at the same time, he was inductively developing (institutional) works that could offer explanatory power to the second author's experience. The fourth and final stage involved both authors, who collaboratively went over the theoretically structured narrative in a back-and-forth fashion until it took its current form (Figure 1).

5. Findings and Discussion

This section delineates the harmonization process (from July 2021 to April 2022) through specific institutional works conducted by the second author as an institutional entrepreneur (Figure 2). The harmonization concerned the establishment of both a NADO and the relevant anti-doping law (see Figure 1). The analysis revealed that everything started with what we refer to here as 'institutional shock'; that is, the (written) warnings from CoE and WADA towards Montenegro that sanctions are underway in case of non-immediate compliance. Through political activity and 'boundary spanning' work, the second author was approached and passed the message that the situation required urgent and concrete actions towards compliance on multiple fronts. After his formal appointment, a combination of technical and political activities was required in order for him to 'scan the environment' and understand in depth not only the inconsistencies, misalignments, and technical ratifications needed from Montenegro's perspective but also whom he could rely upon to proceed

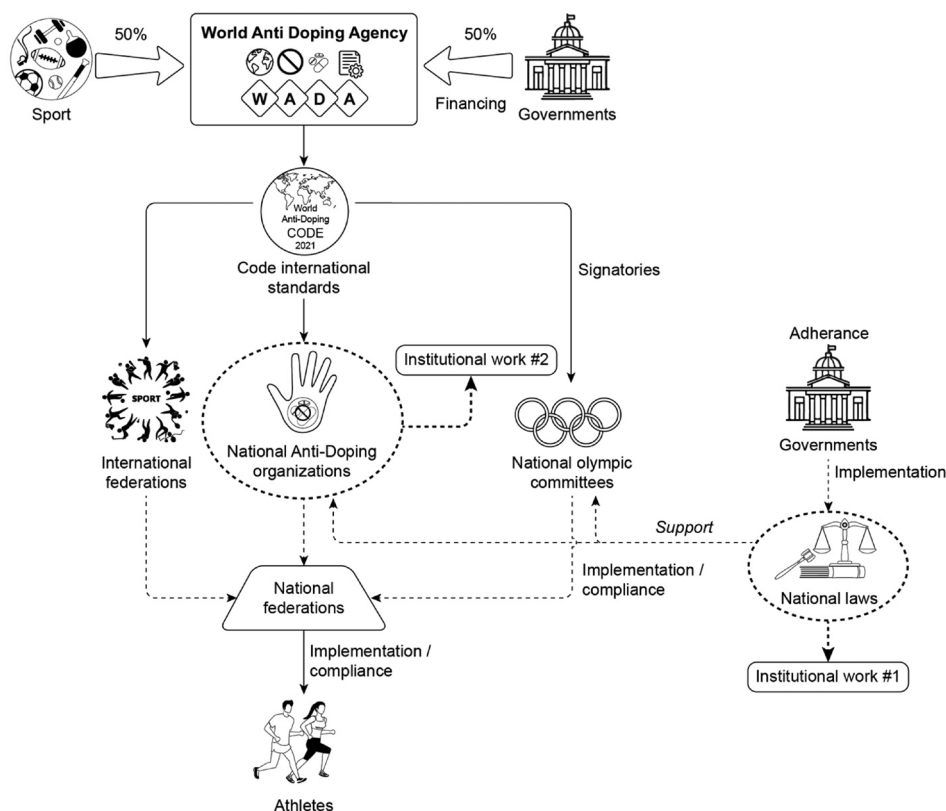


Figure 1. Anti-doping institutional field.

Source: Kamber & Mullis (2010). Modified by the authors to illustrate the national case.

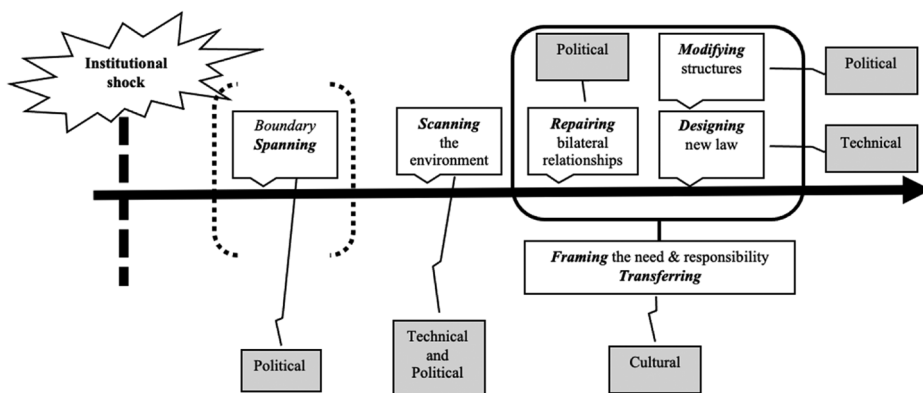


Figure 2. An institutional entrepreneurship process for harmonizing national anti-doping policy.

with the necessary institutional changes. Through another set of political and technical activities, the second author sought to ‘repair’ the bilateral relationships between Montenegro and multiple agencies from the field while ‘designing’ the new legislation and ‘modifying’ institutional structures. However, the crux of his work has been

cultural in nature. That is, for the second author to carry out the abovementioned three works (see [Figure 1](#), the ones inside the box), he had to ‘frame’ the need for these changes by ‘transferring’ the responsibility to political leadership through media pressure. The second author’s following narrative offers a detailed account of all these activities and works that led to the harmonization of Montenegro’s anti-doping policy.

5.1. Institutional Shock

From an institutional standpoint, ‘institutional shocks’ are defined as abrupt and considerable changes or disruptions to the established rules, norms, and frameworks within an organization or society. These shocks can destabilize and impact the functioning of current institutions, requiring them to adapt or transform to meet new circumstances (Micelotta et al., 2017). For instance, the introduction of the World Anti-Doping Code in March 2003 and the UNESCO Convention against Doping in Sport in October 2005 exemplify significant institutional shocks that marked key developments in the regulatory framework of the high-performance sports sector (Houlihan, 2014). In our case, Montenegro’s non-compliance was articulated during the CoE expert visit in 2015. The ratification of most international binding norms did not follow the creation of appropriate institutional regimes and organizational structures that would lead to compliance and implementation processes. The CoE and WADA made several attempts to advise, assist, and support Montenegrin institutions, signatories of the WADC, UNESCO Convention, and CoE Convention to engage with necessary reforms, but there has been no correspondence from Montenegro’s end (T-DO 2021, email communication) ([Email 1](#)).

Montenegro’s failure to fill the self-assessment questionnaire and continuous failures to communicate within the CoE working and ad hoc bodies on anti-doping (CAHAMA and T-DO) led the CoE to approach Montenegrin authorities to help Montenegro avoid institutional conditions for formal decisions of non-compliance-status, with possible suspension for the country’s sport. A virtual meeting was set up for June 21st, 2021, but Montenegrin representatives failed to attend.

The motivation for changes occurred with the institutional shock in the form of possible suspension, opening the perspective to act within existing power-structure relations through changes that focused on norms and values and the creation of institutions as a response to international pressure (Mahoney, 2000). On July 30th I¹ was approached by the CoE representative involved in the matter of anti-doping, specifically from the T-DO Committee, to identify contact points ‘*at the Montenegro ministry responsible for sport in relation to anti-doping legislation.*’ The rationale behind this approach was the worrying situation that, later in August, WADA would find Montenegro non-compliant with the WADC, stating that ‘*Montenegro is the only European country with no formal anti-doping organization.*’ At a meeting on July 30th, I was informed that the CoE offered technical assistance for compliance with WADC and the Anti-Doping Convention; however, Montenegro offered no response (February, June, and July 2021) and failed to reply to the 2020 anti-doping questionnaire. As such, I was offered a consultancy position to establish communication with Montenegro’s representatives from the non-sport and sport movement

Od: sport.t-do <sport.t-do@coe.int>

Date: ner, 30. jyn 2021. y 11:19

Subject: Contacts in the Montenegro ministry responsible for sport

To: [REDACTED]

Cc: [REDACTED]

Dear Mr [REDACTED]

My name is [REDACTED] and I am for many years working at the Council of Europe. I had the pleasure in meeting you on the occasion of some EPAS activities. [REDACTED] kindly gave me your email address, because I need some help in finding contacts at the Montenegro ministry responsible for sport in relation with anti-doping legislation.

The situation with Montenegrin anti-doping is not easy to describe. I can mention several points:

- In mid-August WADA will decide about Montenegro non-compliance with the World Anti-Doping Code
- Montenegro is the only European country with no formal anti-doping organisation
- Council of Europe offered to help Montenegro in compliance with the Code and with the implementations of the Anti-Doping Convention; latest was the meeting on 6 July to which we got no reply from our contacts
- Montenegro didn't reply to the 2020 anti-doping questionnaire

We think that the reason maybe that we don't have the right contact persons. Both WADA and the Council of Europe are determined to provide support in overcoming the structural, legal, and operational issues.

Here are the list of persons we send the communication in the ministry - [REDACTED]

WADA colleagues have contacts with anti-doping people - [REDACTED]; [REDACTED]

We also been in contact with [REDACTED] but we understand that she no longer works for anti-doping.

If you have any advice to us both in terms of contacts or the procedure, we would be immensely grateful. Moreover, please let me know if you would be ready to help us in reaching out to the right people, coordinate and support activities in Montenegro.

With best regards,

[REDACTED]
Senior Programme Manager



Anti-Doping Convention (T-DO) Secretariat /
Secrétariat de la Convention antidopage (T-DO)
DGII Democracy / DGII Démocratie
Council of Europe / Conseil de l'Europe
FR - 67075 Strasbourg Cedex
Tel + 33 (0) 3 88 41 28 77
sport.t-do@coe.int
<http://www.coe.int/sport>

Email 1.

sides. It was hoped that the institutional shock would facilitate efforts to introduce a new institution (NADO MNE) accompanied by the relative regulatory framework (Bourlier-Bargues & Valiorgue, 2019).

5.2. Political Activity: Boundary Spanning

The road to institutional change started by re-establishing communication channels between Montenegrin authorities and the WADA and CoE. Our aim was to liaise between national and international actors to help establish institutional stability through trust, resulting from predictable actions (Arndt & Bigelow, 2005). Following the nature and scope of the problem (issue), a separate meeting was set up for August 5th, with the WADA's representatives in charge of government and NADO affairs. At this meeting, the seriousness of the situation was presented, including certainty of decision on

non-compliance with the possible strict sanctions applied to the sport movement in Montenegro. In that respect, a position paper for the CoE toward Montenegrin authorities was prepared, reflecting a constructive approach with readiness for political and policy support. The discussion moved towards finding a sustainable solution in this peculiarly complex national setting and limited timeframe. In parallel, given the nature of my consultancy role with the CoE, an appropriate communication line was established between July 31st and August 6th, with an official meeting scheduled for August 9th with the public officials (senior level) from the MPNKS, UMS, and from sport movement COK, including the Commission for Anti-Doping. I shared the joint finding from the CoE and WADA in respect to the lack of communication, insufficient technical commitment (filling up self-assessment report), and total failure to respond to the numerous inquiries from the CoE and WADA, which together constitute institutional conditions for non-compliance status and possible suspension for Montenegro's sport. In other words, the crucial task was to rebuild trust and keep the communication channels with the CoE and WADA open to reduce tensions and prepare a timely and effective set of actions.

The solution that I presented presupposed articulation of a formal state position vis-à-vis long-standing challenges. Practically speaking, a note verbale was to be prepared, along with a dynamic plan of activities for how the political, legal, and organizational challenges toward compliance will be addressed and to engage in formal repairing and rebuilding communication. Bartel (2001) states this engagement could be described as a boundary-spanning actor operating in the multilateral and multisectoral political environment, establishing common ground for cooperation. Again, given the nature of my consultancy contract, the CoE supported my initiative to act as a diplomatic brokerage between WADA, on the one hand, and the Government of Montenegro at large and the sport movement in Montenegro, more specifically, on the other.

I prepared a draft letter accompanied by two annexes (Tentative Timeline for Revising Anti-doping Legislation and Tentative Plan for Establishing NADO MNE). After national stakeholders had validated the letter, it was sent to the WADA and CoE on August 10th. The wording was essential in both the CoE's position and Montenegro's note verbale. For starters, while reaffirming the CoE's overall support and technical assistance to Montenegro, it was necessary to highlight the seriousness of the situation. Regarding the latter, a diplomatic note was crafted in such a way that re-assured Montenegro's international partners on state commitment to move the process towards compliance, supplemented by an appropriate political, legal, and institutional action plan.

Perhaps because institutions and their actors often act passively toward the need for reform or change (Oliver, 1991), nothing else was done towards compliance apart from my sending the letter. Regarding the recommendation from the CRC from August 14th, the formal notice of non-compliance was sent to the COK and Commission for Anti-Doping on September 15th. At that time, Montenegro had two options. First, through COK and the Commission for Anti-Doping, it could challenge alleged non-compliance and/or the proposed consequences of non-compliance and/or the reinstatement conditions within 21 days. In that first option, WADA would file a formal notice of dispute with the Court of Arbitration for Sport (CAS) and, according to Article 9.4.4 of the International Standard for Code Compliance

by Signatories (ISCCS), no Signatory Consequences will come into effect unless and until CAS so orders. The second option was to accept the ruling and to expedite the implementation of the annexes communicated back in August. For transitional societies, such as Montenegro, institutional change is commonly sidelined, with obstructions coming as a reflex to reform (Lupova-Henry et al., 2021).

Given the ongoing challenges and institutional incapacity, the change in political climate led to my appointment as the acting director in charge of UMS by the Government of Montenegro on September 23rd. My role was not just to manage the UMS, but also to address the current situation, propose a plan to tackle the challenges, and lay the groundwork for coalition-building and advocacy in Montenegro. In a situation where the country's environment was not conducive to reform, maintaining transparency in our work was of utmost importance. Furthermore, the institutional setting dictated that MPNKS served as a supervisory body to UMS. Therefore, an agreement was reached with the minister of MPNKS and the PM that I would take the lead role on behalf of the government to bypass the current bureaucratic arrangements.

5.3. Technical and Political Activity: Scanning the Environment

The UMS, the nation's highest authority for sport, has approximately 40 employees. Four of those employees had responsibility for overseeing international cooperation, including facilitating communication with the CoE—T-DO and CAHAMA and through the COK Commission for Anti-Doping participating in communication with the WADA. However, there had been no official correspondence with the CoE and WADA for over four years (2017–2021). Further, there was no participation in any official meeting or event held by either the CoE or WADA. Moreover, the institution's archival system regarding international cooperation was almost completely empty, aside from some documents that concerned the European Week of Sport. As for the cooperation between UMS and the COK Commission for Anti-Doping, only two documents for the last three years were in place: the founding act for the Commission by the COK and the remuneration policy for members. Perhaps even more problematic was the absence of any correspondence between the COK Commission and the government itself.

The members of the COK Commission were elected by the COK and UMS, comprised predominantly of politically exposed figures, and not at all associated with either the anti-doping policy or with any prior engagement in sport-related activities. The provisions of the Law on Sport departed from the signatories' obligations towards compliance with the WADC, namely in ensuring the anti-doping institution's legal, functional, and financial independence (NADO). In addition, the National Anti-Doping Platform, which serves for multisectoral cooperation between state and non-state actors, was not established. Within this environment, the first days were the toughest: for example, most employees decided to take leave at that time (somehow provocative), and colleagues who nominally covered legislative affairs or international cooperation had no experience working with international partners. My technical knowledge and political skills were needed, previously exercised in a highly political sport environment.

5.4. Political Activity: Repairing Bilateral Relationships

A former colleague of mine from an international organization confirmed that, practically, there was zero international cooperation between various European sport institutions and Montenegro. This lack of cooperation concerned not just anti-doping but other important topics and emerging themes. In one of my archival searches, I came across an official response to the Delegation of the European Union declining two-year funding for developing initiatives and programs related to the European Week of Sport.

On September 24th, 2021, I informed the CoE and WADA representatives about my formal appointment. The question of strategy to reach compliance depended on several factors, including broader socio-political context, institutional development, and available resources (Pache & Santos, 2010). For example, the latter has been identified as the third most recurring factor that hindered compliance in anti-doping efforts (see Gray, 2019). The priority was to maintain the support provided during the pre-appointment cooperation. To achieve this, I proposed keeping to the timeframe suggested within the annexes discussed earlier. Moreover, I introduced the WADA/CoE representatives to the current political dynamics in Montenegro that were shaping society. Thus, the conclusion presupposed that, before any decision from either side, the validation and consensus on the process were mandatory. In the context of establishing a new anti-doping institution in Montenegro, our external partners noted a lack of human resources and a reluctance from the then-representatives of COK and the Commission for Anti-Doping to share existing data or engage in collaborative efforts. This situation aligns with literature suggesting that even when there is a genuine commitment to compliance, inadequate resources can inadvertently lead to noncompliance. Alternatively, it raises the possibility that the appearance of compliance is deceptive and that a lack of political commitment has led to intentional underfunding (Gray, 2019). As for crafting an anti-doping institutional framework, the dynamic plan for developing an anti-doping policy started with me going through good practices from other countries (Georgian, Lithuanian, and Dutch anti-doping institutional settings). Given the limited timeframe, shared knowledge from the WADA/CoE and myself sped up work on legislation. My existing good relationship with WADA/CoE offered a sense of predictability that the job would be eventually done, which helped repair bilateral relationships.

5.5. Political Activity: Modifying Structures

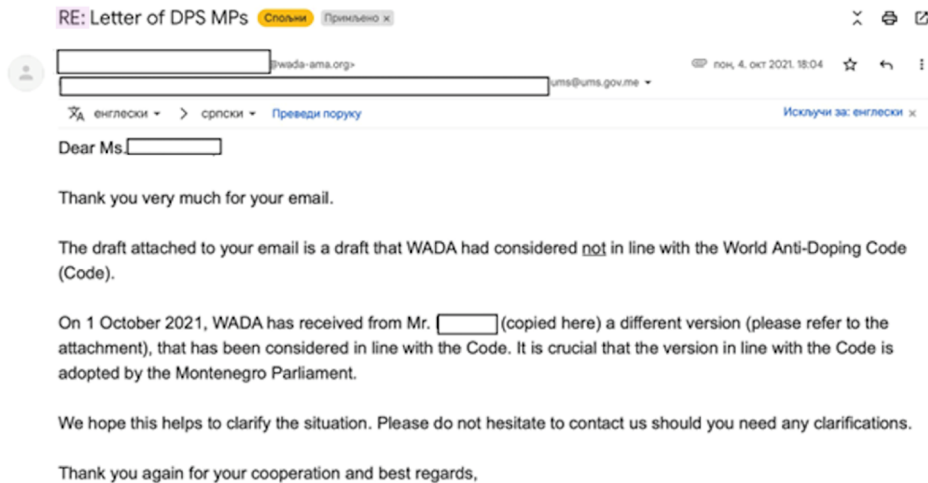
From September 27th, the focus was towards preparing amendments to the Law on Sport. However, as a form of institutional contradiction (Seo & Creed, 2002) reflected in possible tension between ongoing, politicized sport-related governing structures, the challenge was to find a suitable anti-doping institutional framework that would enable compliance with the WADC, particularly Art. 20.5.1; and the organizational structure of NADO that will limit existing political influence, governmental, and sport interference. Therefore, the first step was to enact provisions for establishing the Council as a body within the NADO. The Council's main responsibilities are

to adopt statutes and elect the director. To maintain governance by the WADC, it was stipulated that the Council shall be comprised of individuals who cannot be affiliated with sport organizations, or a representative of government or political parties by strengthening its composition with two provisions: (i) members of the Council will be elected by Council for Sport, COK and POK; (ii) in order to ensure and limit political influence, the members of sport governing members cannot be senior public officials (both state and local) or hold senior positions in the political party, reflecting the new organizational form (Tracey et al., 2011). Between September 27th and October 1st, I organized separate meetings with the COK and Commission for Anti-Doping, where we discussed the activities undertaken to introduce these changes better. I noted that due to the overlap in communication and the seriousness of the situation, UMS would take over the communication channels with the WADA and CoE. This decision was previously discussed and agreed upon with the WADA and CoE in an attempt to expedite the processes.

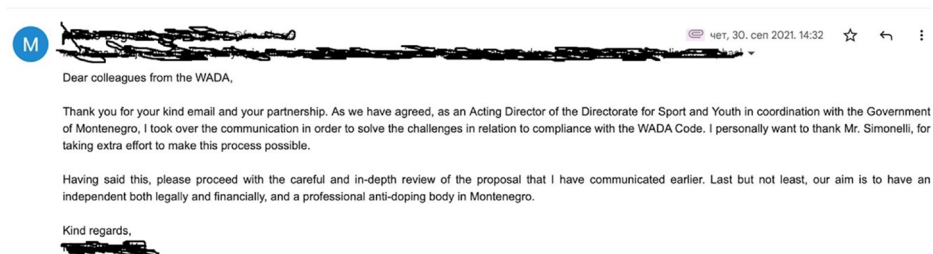
5.6. Technical Activity: Designing the New Law

On September 29th, the amendments were consolidated and sent to WADA for their approval, and on October 1st the WADA confirmed that the draft is in line with the WADC. The next step was to develop a calendar for the adoption of the legislation. The challenge here represented the tense ongoing political situation, additionally fueled by the civic uprising in the old capital of Cetinje. Although no curfew was imposed, the situation was tense and reflected in deeper polarization among MPs and parliamentary groups. This complex socio-political situation was elaborated on by the WADA and CoE representatives, and it was backed by numerous press releases. The polarization resulted in the number of stakeholders acting opposite or contradicting what should be done to resolve institutional challenges associated with non-compliance (Jarzabkowski et al., 2013). For example, even following WADA's approval, the DPS secretary of the parliamentary group sent his own draft of amendments to the current law, disregarding interparliamentary procedures and international cooperation customs. The response from the senior representative of the WADA on October 4th noted that although the trust between UMS and WADA was re-established, that draft was not in line with the WADC while acknowledging and reaffirming the decision from October 1st, highlighting the importance of the Parliament of Montenegro adopting that version (see [Email 2](#) below). At the same time, and during my meetings with WADA, the major topic was the timeframe for adoption. I was informed that the recommendations are to give Montenegro four months to address non-conformity and remove the country from the non-compliant watchlist. This meant that Montenegro would avoid further sanctions, and formal trust among parties was again the case ([Email 3](#)).

During the UNESCO COP8 meeting, the UNESCO Secretariat for Anti-Doping raised several serious questions regarding Montenegro's failure to reach the 60% threshold; therefore, Montenegro was considered non-compliant with the UNESCO Convention. Between 2017 and 2020, the Ministry did not comply with the UNESCO Convention by filling out the self-evaluation form, nor did it participate in or even communicate with the Secretariat. However, given the changes made in September



Email 2.



Email 3.

and the re-establishment of good communication channels and trust with the WADA, Montenegro was given additional time to prepare a Corrective Action Plan that would be discussed following the finalization of the work with the WADA. The rationale behind this was that the work needed for WADA would enable readiness to comply with the 60% threshold using a similar approach through formal rules to facilitate institutional capacity and build institutional memory. This process would equally maintain the development of an anti-doping institutional framework and the establishment of an additional actor (National Platform for Anti-Doping) to ensure compliance through the enforcement of anti-doping policies.

5.7. Cultural Activities: Framing the Need and Transferring Responsibility

The work of 'framing the need' goes beyond the simple support of internal actors, as it represents the crucial step towards securing political support for establishing the anti-doping institution and adopting appropriate anti-doping policies. Consequently, the media had a significant role to play by drawing the attention of the salient stakeholders and the general public, regardless of the political dynamics that resulted in media polarization. It required several meetings with media representatives to

maintain this process as transparently as possible. The tactical work behind these meetings and media appearances was to communicate all the negative examples of sanctioning international athletes and countries and to highlight that this may well be the case (and soon happen to) for Montenegrin athletes and teams. Therefore, the objective was to gain public support to generate MPs readiness to pass anti-doping amendments.

During this process, I often felt that the media was my only internal ally for framing the issue and transferring the responsibility to the politicians. However, this exposure also had certain side effects because athletes and their coaches were becoming increasingly anxious. To keep the process fully transparent, besides consulting with the national sport federations, I held regular meetings with athletes and coaches. They had concerns about possible repercussions resulting from the non-compliance status; athletes from individual and amateur sports living in Montenegro were especially worried not just about their career prospects but crucially about the 'then and there' situation. One athlete, a single parent with a difficult economic status, was worried that sanctions would result in him/her losing the athletic remuneration s/he was receiving and thus becoming unable to provide basic needs for the child. I continuously explained that everything is under control as long as we continue working as agreed with our international partners while pushing the NSFs' stakeholders to maintain ongoing financial and training support for our athletes. I needed to make them feel I was in control, even though I knew we were far from reaching compliance status and avoiding sanctions. However, athletes' concerns and anxiety served as an extra set of motivational factors for me to continue, as I felt these people were supporting my actions while offering me a sort of 'emotional data' to transfer the responsibility to those who had to ratify everything.

The complexity of the political situation required individual consultations with the MPs that were already underway. However, from the outset, members of the government did not act as a team, and I found it difficult to balance policies that were under my sole responsibility with ones that needed concerted effort. During this process, I felt that the MPs generally showed no empathy for Montenegro's sport, except for how to benefit their party's interests or for informal groups to push specific agendas. The emotional data I had gathered from talking with athletes and coaches had little influential power. The DPS tried to disrupt my attempts to conduct reforms, while others sought to benefit by supporting changes as additional amendments about the lifetime compensation. However, I understood that the latter were reluctant to understand the importance of establishing a 'healthier' sport system that could benefit their political agenda in the long run.

There was, of course, an explanation for these silo behaviors. The 42nd Government of Montenegro was predominantly comprised of representatives who were not directly involved in political parties; a so-called 'Expert Government' was under increased pressure, showcasing an ideological heterogeneity. Therefore, in parallel to the consultations, several meetings with the Ministry of Finance were organized to re-arrange budget lines that had already been adopted before my appointment. The aim was to create a specific budget line for a future NADO MNE to enable its financial autonomy.

Secondary to 'framing the need' was establishing swift cooperation with the Secretariat for Legislation to enable technical expertise to finalize the amendments

according to the domestic rules for developing legislation. The Secretariat involved three experts to technically finalize a draft of amendments in the format to pass legal procedure. Important input was given towards establishing a legal entity, making it possible to operate according to domestic legislation while maintaining compliance with the WADC. Following the confirmation from the UMS that the amendments successfully passed all internal legal procedures (approval from the MPNKS, Ministry of Finance, Secretariat for Legislation and governmental commissions), these were sent to the government for adoption. It was on October 25th that the WADA Executive Committee approved the watchlist status for Montenegro. Indeed, the framing represented a key strategic action in maintaining larger support by influencing the political system and, in parallel, enabling its openness (Benford & Snow, 2000).

On November 4th, the government adopted the amendments, and in the form of a proposal, everything was sent to the MNE Parliament for consideration. The MP from the leading parliamentary group warned me that there could be an objection coming from body majority and minority groups as these amendments would jeopardize their own individual positions within sport governing bodies. The media campaign was intensified to keep the topic on the public agenda and highlight the importance of MPs, regardless of political dynamics, to safeguard the integrity of sport and prevent possible repercussions. Between November 4th and November 19th, there was intensive communication (mainly in informal settings) with the MPs regarding the proposed amendments, especially the provision limiting their involvement in sport governing bodies. The specific topic was the future governance of NADO. The original solution presupposed that three of five members of the Council shall be elected by the UMS and two from the sport movement. However, the compromise was that only the sport movement elects NADO MNE Council members. Although the evident lack of human resources and sport professionals in anti-doping was highlighted, this solution would contribute to the autonomy of sport.

With media involvement, the responsibility was transferred to the MNE Parliament by challenging existing power-structure relations by providing new institutional work toward compliance with the WADC (Rao et al., 2003). During the public hearings before two committees (the Committee on Education, Science, Culture and the Sport and Legislative Committee), I used several international examples and wider negative effects, repeating that the responsibility is in the hands of the main legislative body (MNE Parliament) to confirm our international commitment to the integrity of sport; none of the MPs raised any objection to the proposed amendments. This sent a clear message to the nation about (i) the seriousness of the situation in case of non-compliance, (ii) our ability to create an anti-doping institutional framework, and (iii) the potential for strengthening the national sport system based on democratic values and principles of accountability. Of course, I continued using the media focus on anti-doping to stimulate a wider debate on the integrity of sport by highlighting the educational and societal importance of maintaining a 'clean' sport ecosystem. This type of work was close to what (Angus, 1993) called 'valorizing and demonizing'—making the public aware of positive and negative examples that illustrate the normative foundations of an institution (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006).

These media appearances heralded a wider buy-in that helped make small but important steps to shift the cultural norms of what sport is and how it should be used for in Montenegro. A joint statement by the UK and French Ambassadors of Montenegro, highlighting the importance of adhering to international norms, standards, and rules, set the tone of changing the overall cultural approach in governing sport in the country. However, there was little appetite for genuine reforms at the political level. Deep-rooted cultural behaviors do not change overnight, even when there is a high degree of urgency (Lu & Heinze, 2021). Elected MPs did not really care about the athletes' wellbeing (even survival, literally), so I assumed that sport is not an important part of their political portfolios. At the same time (a pure oxymoron, that is), they were going to great lengths to keep the status quo so they can be involved with/in sport organizations and steer political agendas.

Despite all this, as a product of concerted action, the amendments on the Law on Sport were adopted overwhelmingly on November 19th, entering into force on the eighth day of their publication in the *Official Gazette of Montenegro*. Following the adoption, the first of two annexes were implemented five months before it was envisaged, which led to the WADA decision to reinstate Montenegro as compliant as of January 14th, 45 days ahead of deadline. Although they were not important topics within the Law on Sport, several MPs still requested that some of 'their' amendments to be included, those were more products of pure demagoguery rather than clauses meant to serve the development of the sport ecosystem as a whole.

6. Conclusions

6.1. Theoretical and Practical Contributions

Firstly, this study unpacks compliance and implementation of anti-doping policy (any sport policy, for that matter) by elucidating the specific institutional works carried out by an institutional entrepreneur rather than reporting key stakeholders' views, as other empirical studies have done (e.g. Lu & Heinze, 2021; Yang et al., 2022). For example, we complement Lu and Heinze's (2021, p. 13) rigorous and insightful study by interpreting data from 'state legislator(s) [who] would have likely revealed more insight into the effectiveness of institutional entrepreneurs' tactics.' In the same study, the context (youth sport concussion) was characterized by high urgency and low resistance for sport policy change. However, we demonstrate that similar activities and institutional works also apply when the urgency remains high, but the resistance is also high. All this became possible by drawing on the tenets of autoethnography, which facilitated the second author's longitudinal and reflective engagement with the task (McFee, 1993). To our knowledge, no other study has utilized this methodology to capture institutional change through the lens of institutional entrepreneurship.

Secondly, we offer a conceptual model explaining how the harmonization process unfolds through seven institutional works: spanning, scanning, repairing, modifying, designing, framing, and transferring. Our study shows that institutional works by entrepreneurs concerning political activities are based on legitimation reasoning and coalition building (as per Lu & Heinze's work). Crucially, the latter entails a strong international perspective, essentially the factor that legitimizes the need for policy

change. An additional novel element of the conceptual framework is the temporal dynamics of the carried institutional works. We found that the process is less linear, as similar studies have pointed out (e.g. Lu & Heinze, 2021). That is, the cultural activities and the associated works took place in parallel while influencing (and being influenced by) the political and technical activities and the respective institutional works. That was an important finding as it can inform how future policy changes in sport should be strategically practiced.

Thirdly, our study offers the institutional dynamics in a developing European country (Montenegro) with a very particular context by examining the process from non-compliance to compliance. Contrary to Lindblom's (1959) seminal model on policy being developed slowly and incrementally, the constellation of non-compliance and non-existence of appropriate legal and institutional framework required well-thought-through but quick and radical actions. Our findings suggest that the actions would have limited impact without international support due to the nation's political polarization. Against this idiosyncratic context, we propose that in creating (or maintaining) institutions, especially with systems lacking institutional memory or democratic deficits, more transformational yet internationally legitimate policies are the way forward.

6.2. Limitations and Directions for Future Research

This study has certain limitations. First, it draws on a single case, so its findings should be generalized with caution (if at all). As we intended to capture the process through which a NADO and the new anti-doping legislation were established, employing a case study approach was deemed necessary. Relatedly, autoethnographies are based on a subjective (personal) perspective, meaning that if anyone else had done it through his/her own memoirs and observations, the outcome may have been different. Indeed, one may well argue that this introspective approach may lack the objectivity and generalizability required for sound policy analysis. Additionally, the focus on individual narratives can obscure broader social, cultural, and institutional factors, potentially limiting the method's applicability in addressing systemic issues within sport management. Furthermore, there are concerns about the ethical implications of self-disclosure and the potential bias introduced when researchers study environments in which they are personally invested. We hope that we have done our utmost to consider all the valid risks associated with employing a (collaborative) autoethnography.

We welcome more studies of how sport policies unfold in different geographies, cultures, and legal systems through the lenses of institutional entrepreneurship. While accessing data from institutional entrepreneurs may render the task more challenging, collaborative auto-ethnographies may be the answer to accessing firsthand insights from policymakers. Overall, we believe that this micro-theorizing that may result from such a combination (institutional entrepreneurship and (collective) autoethnographies) will help the sport management community grasp how the make-up of these policies (such as the codification of good governance, evaluation schemes for funding sport, etc.) (has) influence(-d) our field's current situation. We hope the present study lays the foundation for more work on these fronts.

Note

1. The autoethnographic approach that this research employs supports the use of the personal pronoun 'I' in the narrative. Creswell (2007) stated that "qualitative researchers tend to embrace the rhetorical assumption that writing needs to be personal and literal in style" (p. 19).

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